

In Exile and Banned from Competing, Afghan Women's Cricket Team Finds a Royal Ally

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On a scorching morning at Clarence House, King Charles gave an enthusiastic welcome to a cricket team that isn't allowed to exist. The Afghan women's cricket team, now in **exile**, cannot represent their country because the **Taliban** regime has banned women's sports. Most players have become **refugees** in Australia after fleeing Afghanistan. "I'm so glad that you can pursue what you want to do," the King told them. The meeting came as the team arrived in England for **exhibition matches**, held alongside the Women's T20 World Cup. They are barred from entering. For the players, the royal encounter was about more than cricket. "It's all about the Afghan women back in our country," said Ekil Latifi, who left Afghanistan in 2021 at age 17 during the chaotic evacuations and hasn't seen her family in five years. "We're here to play cricket but it's not just cricket, we're here to fight for them." Teammate Shabnam Snahtan called it "so disappointing" to miss the World Cup but said the King's public show of **solidarity** "has meant a lot for us." The King, sporting a suit despite the heatwave, received a signed team shirt and had an Afghan Women's XI badge pinned to his lapel. He asked about their escape, the languages they speak, and whether they faced protests as female cricketers. Latifi, now a coach, shared a lesson from the sport: "In life, you get one chance. In cricket, if you're a batter, you might just bat once." The team's survival and this high-profile meeting underscores their dual mission: to keep playing and to be a voice for millions of Afghan women whose dreams are on hold.

Word Treasure

exile -- Being forced to live away from one's home country, often for political reasons.

Taliban -- The Islamic fundamentalist group that currently rules Afghanistan and severely restricts women's rights.

refugees -- People who flee their country due to war, persecution, or disaster and seek safety elsewhere.

exhibition matches -- Sports games played for practice or entertainment, not part of an official competition.

solidarity -- Support or unity among a group, especially in a struggle or to show common purpose.

barred -- Officially prevented from doing or entering something.

Background you need

Clarence House is the official London residence of King Charles III, who became monarch after the death of Queen Elizabeth II in 2022.

The Taliban, a militant group that follows a strict interpretation of Islamic law, took control of Afghanistan in August 2021 and swiftly imposed bans on women's education, work, and sports.

During the US and allied withdrawal from Afghanistan in 2021, many Afghans who had worked for foreign governments or were in danger--including female athletes--were evacuated to countries like Australia and Canada.

The Women's T20 World Cup is a global cricket championship; the Afghan women's team is not recognized by the International Cricket Council because the Taliban government does not allow a national women's team.

Exhibition matches like the ones the team played in England are a way for them to keep their skills sharp and raise awareness of the situation of Afghan women.

Break it down

LEAD: King Charles warmly welcomes exiled Afghan women's cricket team at Clarence House.

+ detail: He was 'enthusiastic,' despite a heatwave.

CONTEXT: Team cannot represent Afghanistan because Taliban banned women's sports; most are refugees in Australia.

MISSION: Players say the meeting is about more than cricket--it's a fight for Afghan women.

+ Latifi: left at 17, hasn't seen family in 5 years.

+ Snahsan: disappointing to miss World Cup, but King's solidarity means a lot.

MEETING DETAILS: King received signed shirt, pinned badge, asked about escape, languages, protests.

CRICKET AS METAPHOR: Latifi's lesson about one chance in life and batting.

UNRESOLVED: The team's dual mission of playing and being a voice continues as they play exhibition matches.

Why it matters

The team's story highlights how sports can be a powerful platform for human rights, giving a voice to Afghan women whose freedoms have been stripped away. It also shows the emotional impact of exile and the enduring hope for change under oppressive regimes.

Test what you remember

1. Why can't the Afghan women's cricket team represent their country?

- ☐ (A) They lack funding
- ☐ (B) The Taliban regime banned women's sports
- ☐ (C) They chose to play for Australia
- ☐ (D) The International Cricket Council suspended Afghanistan

2. Where have most of the team members become refugees?

- ☐ (A) England
- ☐ (B) Pakistan
- ☐ (C) Australia
- ☐ (D) India

3. Who hosted the team at Clarence House?

- ☐ (A) Prince William
- ☐ (B) Queen Elizabeth
- ☐ (C) King Charles
- ☐ (D) The British Prime Minister

4. How did the King show solidarity with the team?

- ☐ (A) He wore their team shirt
- ☐ (B) He pinned an Afghan Women's XI badge to his lapel
- ☐ (C) He announced funding for the team
- ☐ (D) He promised to ban Afghanistan from international sports

5. According to Ekil Latifi, what is the team's mission beyond cricket?

- ☐ (A) Political asylum in England
- ☐ (B) The rights of Afghan women back home
- ☐ (C) Better cricket equipment
- ☐ (D) To join the men's national team

6. What lesson did Ekil Latifi share from cricket about life?

- ☐ (A) You only get one chance
- ☐ (B) Practice makes perfect
- ☐ (C) Teamwork is everything
- ☐ (D) Never give up

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

- 1. Royal spotlight:** King Charles's high-profile backing brings international attention to the team and the plight of Afghan women, possibly pressuring world cricket bodies and governments to take a stand against the Taliban's bans.
- 2. Symbolic but insufficient:** Some might argue that gestures like this are not enough; without concrete action, the Taliban's policies remain unchanged and the team still cannot compete officially, raising questions about the effectiveness of symbolic meetings.
- 3. Diplomatic tightrope:** The situation reflects the broader challenge of balancing diplomatic relations with human rights advocacy, as governments and international organizations struggle to engage with the Taliban while condemning their policies.
- 4. Path to recognition:** If the team can gain official recognition from the International Cricket Council, they could become a full member and inspire other exiled athletes, but this depends on political developments in Afghanistan and sustained international pressure.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):